



Grand Bazaar of Tehran

Ornate arches top the busy walkways in this historic market in Tehran where people have come to shop for goods for centuries.



Guided by the stars

Brass astrolabes helped the ancient Persians measure the positions of the sun and stars and find the direction of the holy city of Mecca.

Gardens of paradise

The ancient Persians were the first to design landscaped gardens, which became common in Islamic architecture. Eram Garden, in the city of Shiraz, ranks among the finest in Iran.



Tehran is sheltered by the snowcapped Elburz Mountains in the north.



The ancient city of **Susa** is located at the foot of the Zagros Mountains.

Harvesting by hand

Most of the world's saffron spice comes from Iran. It is obtained from the delicate purple flowers of the saffron crocus, which are picked by hand.



- 📏 636,372 sq miles (1,648,195 sq km)
- 👤 84.9 million
- ★ Tehran
- 🗣️ Farsi, Azeri, other languages (+7)

Iran



Zerehs polo

This Iranian steamed rice dish is flavored with aromatic saffron and zesty barberries and is usually served with chicken.



Elite fighters

This mosaic from the ancient city of Susa depicts the first Persian Empire's most elite warriors. This force was called the "Immortals" because whenever a soldier died, they were replaced by another so the unit always had 10,000 members.

Iran, formerly called **Persia**, is home to a civilization dating back to the 6th century BCE, known for **poetry, rug weaving, and metalwork**. Iran's rich cultural heritage is seen in its mix of **ethnic groups, architectural styles, and local customs**.